

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Government and Public Administration English



Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For public administrators, agency program managers, policy analysts, procurement staff, constituent-service teams, grants managers, and interagency coordinators.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Policy Implementation and Program Rules

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

02 Public Meetings and Stakeholder Input

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

03 Procurement and Vendor Selection

Clarify missing information before responding.

04 Grants, Compliance, and Reporting

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

05 Interagency Coordination

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

06 Constituent Services and Escalation

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

07 Transparency, Records, and Ethics

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

08 Performance Metrics and Budget Justification

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Policy Implementation and Program Rules

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

A resident mistakes draft eligibility guidance for a final rule. The office has published current guidance and a separate proposal.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

policy - Formal rule or standard that guides decisions and behavior.

eligibility - Rules that determine whether a person, account, provider, service, or request qualifies for a program, benefit, or action.

implementation - Putting an agreed plan, product, or process into operation.

public guidance - Official information explaining how a public program or process operates.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Compare this wording: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
 - B. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
 - C. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. How would you describe the next step in your own words?
 - B. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?
 - C. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The proposal is not current eligibility guidance

The lesson's office has current guidance and a separate proposal; a constituent-facing team needs to explain the difference after a resident confuses them.

01 • Constituent services officer: A resident read the proposal and thought it changed eligibility immediately. How should I explain the distinction?

02 • Policy officer: Explain that current public guidance describes the present process, while the separate proposal describes a possible change.

03 • Constituent services officer: So publishing a proposal doesn't itself establish that its eligibility provisions are now in effect?

04 • Policy officer: Correct. We should direct the resident to the current guidance without deciding their individual eligibility here.

05 • Constituent services officer: Could I describe the proposal as the next version of the policy, to make it simpler?

06 • Policy officer: That would suggest its adoption is certain. Keep the proposed status explicit instead.

07 • Constituent services officer: I'll say the proposal is under consideration, not a replacement for the current published guidance.

08 • Policy officer: Good. Also use the actual document labels so the resident can distinguish the two sources.

09 • Constituent services officer: And if they ask about their own application, I'll refer the question through the relevant case process.

10 • Policy officer: Exactly. A clear explanation of document status helps without inventing a decision about their circumstances.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

An effective date and a training date

Separate fictional case: an office's approved service procedure begins on Monday; staff training occurred last Thursday. A supervisor confuses the training date with implementation.

01 • Front-desk supervisor: Staff learned the new procedure last Thursday. Does that mean implementation began when the training finished?

02 • Program officer: No. In this fictional program, the approved start date is Monday; training prepared staff for that change.

03 • Front-desk supervisor: Then a training session and an effective date answer different questions about the policy?

04 • Program officer: Yes. One concerns preparation, while the other tells us when the approved procedure starts.

05 • Front-desk supervisor: What should we say about cases received before Monday? The training notes don't explain that.

06 • Program officer: Identify that as an unresolved transition question and ask the policy owner for the applicable guidance.

07 • Front-desk supervisor: I shouldn't assume the new procedure applies retrospectively simply because the staff have been trained.

08 • Program officer: Correct. Explain what we know, and don't create a transition rule to fill the gap.

09 • Front-desk supervisor: I'll brief the team on Monday's start date and flag earlier cases for clarification.

10 • Program officer: I'll obtain the transition explanation so public guidance and staff practice use the same confirmed information.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Meeting a condition versus receiving a decision

Separate fictional case: a fictional program's guidance lists several eligibility conditions, and a service team is discussing a caller who mentions only one condition.

01 • Service adviser: The caller meets one listed condition. Could I tell them that means their application will be approved?

02 • Program coordinator: Not from that information. Meeting one condition is different from completing the program's eligibility assessment.

03 • Service adviser: How can I explain that without sounding as though I am discouraging them from applying?

04 • Program coordinator: Say that the guidance lists several conditions and the responsible team assesses the required information.

05 • Service adviser: So I can acknowledge the information they provided without announcing an outcome we haven't determined.

06 • Program coordinator: Exactly. Public guidance explains the process; an individual decision applies that process to a particular case.

07 • Service adviser: Would it help to ask which part of the guidance they want explained next?

08 • Program coordinator: Yes. Answer within your role and refer questions requiring a case decision to the authorized team.

09 • Service adviser: I'll distinguish understanding the conditions from confirming eligibility, and avoid predicting an approval date.

10 • Program coordinator: Good. That keeps the explanation useful while preserving the limits of what we actually know.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Policy Implementation and Program Rules

A resident mistakes draft eligibility guidance for a final rule. The office has published current guidance and a separate proposal.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: The proposal is under review; the current published guidance remains the reference for today's process. Let me show you the distinction and where official updates will appear.

Scenario 2 | A summary leaflet and the full guidance

In a fictional program, a short leaflet omits a condition that appears in the current full guidance. No decision has been made on a caller's case. Discuss how the service team should explain the difference and seek correction of the leaflet.

Role A: You are the service supervisor. Explain why a shortened leaflet is not an individual eligibility decision.

Role B: You are the policy coordinator. Clarify the authoritative internal source and arrange review of the omission.

Possible opening: The leaflet is a summary, and it omits a condition that appears in the current full guidance.

Success checks

- Explain summary guidance versus an individual decision.
- Acknowledge the confusing omission without inventing a remedy.
- Agree an authorized clarification and leaflet-review next step.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to promise approval because the caller relied on the leaflet.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Public Meetings and Stakeholder Input

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

SITUATION

At a public meeting, two speakers use most of the time and several people have not been heard. The meeting has an announced participation process.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

public comment - Input submitted by members of the public in a defined consultation process.

stakeholder - Person or group with an interest, risk, authority, or dependency in the work.

public record - A record held by a public body that is subject to applicable records rules.

facilitation - Guiding a discussion so people can contribute, understand differences, and reach useful next steps.

3. Notice the language

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Compare this wording: Nobody objected, so everyone agrees.

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Help a group reach a clear next step

4. Check the language

1. Which phrase invites a missing perspective?
 - A. We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view?
 - B. The remote team has been quiet, so they must agree.
 - C. We can record their agreement without asking them.
2. Which closing statement records an unresolved decision accurately?
 - A. We discussed the options, so approval is complete.
 - B. Everyone spoke, so the decision must be final.
 - C. Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Return to the announced participation process

At the lesson's public meeting, two speakers have used most of the time and several participants remain unheard; an announced participation process exists.

01 • Meeting facilitator: We've heard extensively from two speakers, while several participants are still waiting to contribute.

02 • Committee clerk: Should we invite another round from the same speakers to clarify their disagreements first?

03 • Meeting facilitator: Let's follow the announced participation process and give the waiting participants their opportunity for public comment.

04 • Committee clerk: I can check the current speaking order. We shouldn't create a new allocation rule during the discussion.

05 • Meeting facilitator: Agreed. Please identify whose turn comes next, and I'll explain how we're returning to that process.

06 • Committee clerk: Should the audience understand these comments as decisions by the committee or as stakeholder input?

07 • Meeting facilitator: As input. We'll clarify the actual decision process rather than imply that speaking time determines the outcome.

08 • Committee clerk: I'll keep the public record clear about comments received and any committee action that actually occurs.

09 • Meeting facilitator: Thank you. I'll invite the next participant and ask everyone to respect the announced process.

10 • Committee clerk: I'll support the speaking order and flag any remaining participants before this agenda item closes.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Remote participants have lost the audio

Separate fictional case: a hybrid consultation meeting has remote participants, but they report missing the last explanation of two service options. No decision has been taken.

01 • Meeting chair: Remote participants report that they missed the explanation of the two options because the audio dropped.

02 • Consultation officer: Shall we continue with comments from the room while the technical team investigates the connection?

03 • Meeting chair: We need to avoid treating the remote group as informed when they haven't heard the same explanation.

04 • Consultation officer: I can ask the technical team to check audio and identify which section needs repeating.

05 • Meeting chair: Please do. Then we'll restate both options before seeking further comments under the announced process.

06 • Consultation officer: Should I mark the earlier silence from remote participants as agreement with the proposal?

07 • Meeting chair: No. Silence during an audio problem doesn't establish a stakeholder view or consent.

08 • Consultation officer: Understood. I'll note the access problem in the meeting record without attributing opinions to absent voices.

09 • Meeting chair: Once the connection is checked, I'll invite questions and confirm that participants heard the summary.

10 • Consultation officer: I'll track any unresolved access issue so we can determine the appropriate follow-up before closing consultation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A technical answer does not settle a value question

Separate fictional case: a public workshop compares longer library hours with more mobile visits; the cost briefing is complete, but access advocates have not yet spoken.

01 • Workshop facilitator: We've heard the cost briefing. Before summarizing, I'd like to hear from stakeholders concerned about access.

02 • Budget liaison: The less expensive option is already clear. Would more discussion change the figures we presented?

03 • Workshop facilitator: It may not change the figures, but it can identify effects that the cost comparison doesn't capture.

04 • Budget liaison: So the public comment stage isn't simply a vote on whichever option has the lower cost?

05 • Workshop facilitator: Correct. We need to hear relevant concerns and explain how the responsible body will consider them.

06 • Budget liaison: I'll restate the cost assumptions briefly, then leave room for comments about service access.

07 • Workshop facilitator: Thank you. Let's avoid presenting the budget briefing as a decision that has already been made.

08 • Budget liaison: I'll distinguish the evidence we supplied from any recommendation the decision makers later adopt.

09 • Workshop facilitator: After the remaining voices are heard, I'll summarize agreements, differences, and the next decision step.

10 • Budget liaison: I'll check that the summary preserves the financial limits without erasing the access concerns participants raised.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Public Meetings and Stakeholder Input

At a public meeting, two speakers use most of the time and several people have not been heard. The meeting has an announced participation process.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Second round: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Model for scenario 1: Let's return to the announced speaking process so more people can contribute. I'll summarize the points raised and invite the next speaker, while keeping the record clear about what remains unresolved.

Scenario 2 | A correction to the consultation summary

At a fictional transport consultation, the draft spoken summary says all participants prefer option A. The clerk's notes show one participant supported B and another asked for more information. Reopen the summary briefly and agree accurate wording.

Role A: You are the facilitator. Invite correction without restarting the entire debate.

Role B: You are the committee clerk. State the recorded differences and distinguish them from a formal decision.

Possible opening: Before we close, I need to correct the impression that everyone supported option A.

Success checks

- Include the differing recorded views.
- Distinguish consultation input from a formal decision.
- Close with an accurate summary and identify who will confirm the next decision-process step.

Add a complication: The meeting sponsor asks you to describe the discussion as unanimous for simplicity.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Procurement and Vendor Selection

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

A procurement evaluation note uses "best value" without linking the judgment to published evaluation criteria.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

RFP - Request for proposals: an invitation to submit an approach and offer for specified work.

evaluation criteria - The stated standards used to compare or assess options or performance.

bidder - A person or organization submitting an offer in a procurement process.

procurement rule - A requirement governing how purchasing or supplier selection must be conducted.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Compare this wording: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when does the review start?
 - B. Could you confirm when starts the review?
 - C. Could you confirm when the review starts?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Who will present the report at the meeting?
 - B. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?
 - C. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

What does best value refer to?

The lesson's procurement evaluation note says best value without connecting that judgment to the published evaluation criteria.

01 • Procurement officer: The evaluation note says best value. Which published evaluation criteria support that judgment about the bidder?

02 • Evaluation panel member: The note doesn't identify them, so I need to revisit the evaluation record before explaining the conclusion.

03 • Procurement officer: Please clarify the evidence and criterion rather than add a general statement that the proposal feels stronger.

04 • Evaluation panel member: Would a comment about the bidder's reputation be enough to make the explanation more concrete?

05 • Procurement officer: Only the applicable evaluation framework can establish what belongs in the assessment. We shouldn't invent a criterion.

06 • Evaluation panel member: Then I should identify the relevant RFP requirement and the recorded evidence against it.

07 • Procurement officer: Yes. Here, RFP means request for proposals; its stated criteria matter to a traceable explanation.

08 • Evaluation panel member: I'll also ask for clarification if the record doesn't show how the judgment was reached.

09 • Procurement officer: Good. Keep the uncertainty visible rather than retrospectively presenting an unsupported rationale as established.

10 • Evaluation panel member: I'll return with the criterion-linked evidence or a precise question for the authorized procurement review.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

An optional feature in the scoring discussion

Separate fictional case: a fictional RFP scores response time and implementation support; a panel member wants to award points for a dashboard feature not listed in those criteria.

01 • Panel chair: You mentioned awarding points for the dashboard. Which listed evaluation criterion would that assessment relate to?

02 • Technical evaluator: The RFP scores response time and implementation support. I don't see a separate dashboard criterion.

03 • Panel chair: Then we need procurement clarification before treating the feature as an additional scored advantage.

04 • Technical evaluator: Could it be evidence of implementation support rather than a new criterion in its own right?

05 • Panel chair: Possibly, but we should ask how the published framework applies rather than decide that informally here.

06 • Technical evaluator: I'll identify the feature and explain the proposed connection without changing the scoring sheet.

07 • Panel chair: Please also bring the exact proposal passage, so the question concerns documented evidence.

08 • Technical evaluator: Understood. Enthusiasm for a feature isn't enough to establish that it should affect the bidder's score.

09 • Panel chair: We'll seek the authorized interpretation and keep the current assessment status explicit while that question is open.

10 • Technical evaluator: I'll prepare the focused question and avoid adding a scoring rule during the discussion.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A quote with unclear installation scope

Separate fictional case: an evaluator compares two equipment bids; one clearly includes installation, while the other does not state whether installation is included.

01 • Procurement analyst: One bid includes installation. Could you confirm how installation is treated in the other bidder's quoted price?

02 • Technical reviewer: The second proposal doesn't say. I had assumed installation was included because the equipment is the same.

03 • Procurement analyst: Let's preserve that as unknown. The equipment description doesn't establish the scope of the quoted service.

04 • Technical reviewer: Should I contact the bidder directly and ask them to revise the price for installation?

05 • Procurement analyst: Use the authorized clarification process. We shouldn't improvise a contact or revision process in this discussion.

06 • Technical reviewer: Then I'll send procurement the exact ambiguity and the passages that need clarification.

07 • Procurement analyst: Good. We also need to distinguish clarifying the existing offer from requesting a changed offer.

08 • Technical reviewer: Until that distinction is resolved, I won't label the second bid cheaper on a like-for-like basis.

09 • Procurement analyst: Exactly. Our question should be specific enough for the responsible procurement team to handle appropriately.

10 • Technical reviewer: I'll mark installation scope unresolved and ask how it should be addressed under this procurement's rules.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Procurement and Vendor Selection

A procurement evaluation note uses "best value" without linking the judgment to published evaluation criteria.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: Which stated criteria support that assessment? Please connect the evidence to those criteria so the review explains the basis for the judgment rather than relying on a general label.

Scenario 2 | Two versions of an evaluation sheet

A fictional panel has two evaluation-sheet versions with different criterion labels. The procurement officer has not confirmed which version applies. Discuss how to clarify the approved sheet before scoring continues.

Role A: You are the panel coordinator. Identify the version mismatch and ask for confirmation.

Role B: You are the procurement officer. Request both versions and their sources without guessing which is authoritative.

Possible opening: Could you confirm which evaluation-sheet version applies? The two copies use different criterion labels.

Success checks

- Identify the version ambiguity specifically.
- Avoid selecting criteria based on a preferred result.
- Agree an authorized version check before scoring resumes.

Add a complication: A panel member wants to use whichever sheet gives their preferred bidder the higher score.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Grants, Compliance, and Reporting

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

SITUATION

A grant report contains a total expenditure figure but lacks the requested supporting categories.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

grant - Funding provided for an agreed purpose subject to stated conditions.

subrecipient - An organization receiving a portion of an award to carry out part of a funded program.

allowable cost - An expense permitted under the rules or agreement governing a grant or program.

reporting - Communicating required or useful information in a defined form or process.

3. Notice the language

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Compare this wording: Please revert soonest with the necessary.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask for an actionable next step

4. Check the language

1. What does 'Please send it by Thursday' normally mean?
 - A. Keep sending it regularly until Thursday.
 - B. Send it no later than Thursday.
 - C. Send it on Thursday, but not earlier.
2. Which request gives the recipient enough detail to act?
 - A. Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?
 - B. Could you confirm that the review is important?
 - C. Could you confirm that you received my earlier message?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The total needs supporting categories

The lesson's grant report contains total expenditure but omits the supporting categories requested for reporting.

01 • Grants officer: Could you provide the expenditure breakdown in the requested categories so we can review this grant report?

02 • Program accountant: The total is already included. Do you need the categories even if the overall amount is unchanged?

03 • Grants officer: Yes. The total doesn't show how expenditure relates to the reporting categories or supporting records.

04 • Program accountant: Should I divide the total evenly between the categories to produce a complete-looking report?

05 • Grants officer: No. Please use the actual records and identify anything that cannot yet be allocated accurately.

06 • Program accountant: Understood. I'll check the source entries and ask the relevant owners about any unclear classifications.

07 • Grants officer: Please also flag items needing allowable-cost review rather than treating inclusion in a total as approval.

08 • Program accountant: I can explain what information is available and estimate the remaining preparation time after checking the records.

09 • Grants officer: That would help. Let me know the realistic timing instead of assuming a new reporting deadline.

10 • Program accountant: I'll return with the supported breakdown and a separate list of unresolved entries for review.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A subrecipient's missing reporting period

Separate fictional case: a subrecipient submits a cost schedule labeled quarter total without dates; the grant team needs the April-through-June reporting period.

01 • Grant reporting coordinator: Could you confirm the dates covered by your quarter total? Our request concerns April through June.

02 • Subrecipient finance officer: The schedule label is incomplete. I'll check the underlying records rather than assume it covers those months.

03 • Grant reporting coordinator: Please send the date range with the supporting schedule so we can match it to the reporting period.

04 • Subrecipient finance officer: If the schedule includes another month, would you like me to adjust the total from memory?

05 • Grant reporting coordinator: No. Reconcile it to the dated records and identify any adjustment clearly.

06 • Subrecipient finance officer: Understood. The request is for a supported period-specific schedule, not just a renamed attachment.

07 • Grant reporting coordinator: Exactly. Could you tell me when you can confirm the period after checking the source entries?

08 • Subrecipient finance officer: I'll check access to those entries today and then give you a realistic response time.

09 • Grant reporting coordinator: Thank you. We'll keep the period match open until the dates and amounts are verified.

10 • Subrecipient finance officer: I'll send the confirmed range, supporting detail, and any remaining question through our reporting channel.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An invoice without the grant reference

Separate fictional case: a fictional grant report includes an invoice for shared training, but no allocation record links the charge to this grant.

01 • Grant reviewer: Please provide the allocation record for this shared training invoice so we can review the amount charged here.

02 • Program finance lead: The training benefited several projects. Is the invoice alone insufficient to explain this grant's share?

03 • Grant reviewer: It shows a supplier charge, but it doesn't establish how the grant allocation was calculated.

04 • Program finance lead: I'll ask the budget owner for the basis and supporting record used for the allocation.

05 • Grant reviewer: Thank you. Keep any allowable-cost question separate; I haven't approved the charge by requesting more evidence.

06 • Program finance lead: Could we submit the current report while labeling that item as reviewed to avoid another delay?

07 • Grant reviewer: Initial review identified missing allocation evidence; we must not describe the charge as approved or the review as complete.

08 • Program finance lead: Understood. I'll report the gap explicitly and request the applicable submission instruction.

09 • Grant reviewer: Please confirm when the allocation evidence can be supplied and whether any source record is unavailable.

10 • Program finance lead: I'll return with those details, without inventing a split or implying the expense is already accepted.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Grants, Compliance, and Reporting

A grant report contains a total expenditure figure but lacks the requested supporting categories.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: Could you provide the category breakdown and supporting references required for this report? If an item is unresolved, please identify it so the grants team can explain the next step.

Scenario 2 | An undated exchange-rate calculation

A fictional grant schedule converts a supplier payment into reporting currency, but the conversion date and rate source are missing. The required grant method has not been checked. Request the information needed for review without choosing a rate yourself.

Role A: You are the grant reviewer. Ask for the method, date, and source supporting the conversion.

Role B: You are the subrecipient accountant. Explain what you must verify and offer a realistic response check.

Possible opening: Could you provide the conversion date and rate source so we can check this amount against the grant's reporting method?

Success checks

- Request the missing calculation evidence precisely.
- Do not invent the grant's required conversion method.
- Agree ownership and timing for the clarification.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests using today's rate because it is easiest to find.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Interagency Coordination

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

SITUATION

Two agencies are coordinating a service request. Each assumes the other will contact the resident.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

jurisdiction - The legal authority of a court or public body over a matter or area.

memorandum of understanding - A document recording parties' shared intentions or arrangements; legal effects depend on its terms.

data sharing - Making data available to another person or organization under appropriate conditions.

owner - Named person or role accountable for a decision, action, deliverable, or risk.

3. Notice the language

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Compare this wording: Someone should follow up on this.

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Transfer information and responsibility

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence checks that responsibility has been accepted?
 - A. Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.
 - B. I mentioned the check in my earlier email.
 - C. The check appears somewhere in the notes.
2. Which response best checks a critical handoff detail?
 - A. I assume all results are final, so we can finish.
 - B. I saw the message, so no clarification is needed.
 - C. So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Name the resident-contact owner

The lesson's two agencies each assume the other will contact the resident about a coordinated service request.

01 • Agency liaison: We've both assumed the other agency would contact the resident. We need to assign that responsibility explicitly.

02 • Partner agency coordinator: Agreed. Which part of the service request are you handing over, and what information is available?

03 • Agency liaison: First, let's confirm who owns the contact under our coordination arrangement; I shouldn't assume your agency accepts it.

04 • Partner agency coordinator: I'll check our role and jurisdiction before accepting the casework action on behalf of my team.

05 • Agency liaison: Please also confirm what information can be transferred under the applicable data-sharing arrangement.

06 • Partner agency coordinator: Yes. A memorandum of understanding may describe responsibilities, but we need its actual terms, not assumptions.

07 • Agency liaison: Until that is checked, I'll keep the contact action open and avoid telling the resident it has happened.

08 • Partner agency coordinator: I'll return with a named owner or a specific unresolved responsibility question for our supervisors.

09 • Agency liaison: Once agreed, let's read back who contacts the resident and who confirms completion to the other agency.

10 • Partner agency coordinator: That will make the handoff explicit and prevent the same gap from continuing unnoticed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A transfer that has not been accepted

Separate fictional case: an agency emailed a referral to a partner office; the partner's automatic receipt arrived, but no case owner has acknowledged acceptance.

01 • Referral coordinator: The partner office's automatic receipt arrived, but we don't yet have acceptance from a named case owner.

02 • Service manager: Can I mark the referral handed over, since we know the email reached their system?

03 • Referral coordinator: Receipt confirms delivery, not responsibility. We need acknowledgment of the requested next action.

04 • Service manager: Please follow up with the partner coordinator and ask who will review the referral.

05 • Referral coordinator: I will. I'll use the existing reference rather than resend unnecessary personal information.

06 • Service manager: Good. The data-sharing boundary matters even when we're trying to speed up interagency coordination.

07 • Referral coordinator: Until someone accepts the handoff, our tracker should show sent and awaiting acknowledgment, not completed.

08 • Service manager: Agreed. Who will maintain the status and tell our service team when acceptance is confirmed?

09 • Referral coordinator: I'll own that follow-up and report any jurisdiction question the receiving office raises.

10 • Service manager: Thank you. Keep the resident-facing explanation consistent with the actual transfer status.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Two tasks, two agency owners

Separate fictional case: a coordinated community-center reopening requires a facilities inspection and a public-information update; the facilities agency owns inspection, and the service agency owns communications.

01 • Facilities liaison: Our agency owns the inspection, while yours owns the public-information update. The inspection result isn't available yet.

02 • Service communications coordinator: Then I can prepare wording, but I shouldn't announce that the center is cleared to reopen.

03 • Facilities liaison: Correct. I'll provide the verified inspection status through the agreed coordination channel when it is available.

04 • Service communications coordinator: Could you also confirm who will tell us if the result requires another action?

05 • Facilities liaison: I'll coordinate that notification. I won't leave your team to infer it from an internal inspection entry.

06 • Service communications coordinator: I'll keep the public update pending and identify communications as our responsibility, not your agency's task.

07 • Facilities liaison: Please read back the dependency so we know both teams share the same understanding.

08 • Service communications coordinator: You provide the inspection result; we review the public wording against that result before publishing an update.

09 • Facilities liaison: Exactly. Neither a prepared statement nor a planned reopening date establishes inspection clearance.

10 • Service communications coordinator: Agreed. I'll brief our team and confirm receipt when your verified status arrives.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Interagency Coordination

Two agencies are coordinating a service request. Each assumes the other will contact the resident.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Second round: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Model for scenario 1: Could we confirm which agency will make the next contact and by when? I'll record that responsibility and the permitted information-sharing route so the resident receives a coordinated response.

Scenario 2 | A liaison changes during a referral

In a fictional interagency case, the original partner liaison has moved roles. A referral is still pending, and a replacement contact has been named but has not acknowledged the action. Conduct a handoff without treating the replacement's name as acceptance.

Role A: You are the sending liaison. Summarize the pending action using the existing case reference.

Role B: You are the receiving coordinator. Confirm what you can accept and identify any authority question.

Possible opening: This referral still needs an acknowledged owner following the liaison change.

Success checks

- State the pending action rather than merely transfer a name.
- Seek explicit responsibility acknowledgment.
- Keep personal information within the agreed sharing process.

Add a complication: The old liaison's automated reply says all matters are now with the replacement.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Constituent Services and Escalation

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

SITUATION

A resident has been redirected between offices without an explanation of who can address the issue.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

constituent - A person served or represented by a public official or institution.

casework - Work performed to help an individual navigate a service, issue, or administrative process.

appeal - A request for a decision to be reviewed through an established process.

authority - The recognized power to decide, act, or provide an authoritative basis for a conclusion.

3. Notice the language

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Compare this wording: I'm sorry if you failed to understand.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Repair a misunderstanding

4. Check the language

1. Which apology takes responsibility for unclear wording?
 - A. I'm sorry the process took longer than expected.
 - B. I'm sorry we could not meet the original date.
 - C. I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear.
2. What should follow an apology for an incorrect date?
 - A. A new guaranteed date even if it is unverified.
 - B. The corrected date and the current confirmation status.
 - C. A longer explanation that never states the correct date.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Repairing an unexplained referral loop

The lesson's resident has been redirected repeatedly; a constituent-services supervisor coaches the officer responsible for the next response.

01 • Constituent services officer: The resident has been sent between offices without an explanation. Our next response needs to acknowledge that.

02 • Casework supervisor: Yes. What can you correct without claiming we have authority to resolve the underlying issue ourselves?

03 • Constituent services officer: I can say our earlier referrals didn't explain which office could address the matter or why.

04 • Casework supervisor: Good. Then verify the responsible office before sending the resident through another unsupported referral.

05 • Constituent services officer: Should I describe the next contact as an appeal so it sounds like a stronger escalation?

06 • Casework supervisor: Not unless that is the applicable process. An escalation and a formal appeal are not interchangeable labels.

07 • Constituent services officer: I'll check the casework route and explain its purpose in plain language once it is confirmed.

08 • Casework supervisor: Also distinguish our coordination role from the receiving office's decision-making authority.

09 • Constituent services officer: Understood. I'll acknowledge the confusion, confirm the route, and avoid promising a particular decision.

10 • Casework supervisor: That gives the resident a clearer next step without adding another misleading expectation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A receipt letter mistaken for approval

Separate fictional case: a constituent-services email called an application accepted when it had only been received; the decision remains pending.

01 • Service officer: Our email used accepted when we meant received. I need to correct that before another response goes out.

02 • Casework manager: What misunderstanding could that wording have created for the applicant and our front-desk team?

03 • Service officer: They may believe the application was approved, although the decision is still pending.

04 • Casework manager: Then state that distinction directly and acknowledge that our wording was confusing.

05 • Service officer: I'll explain that receipt means the office has the application, not that the requested outcome is granted.

06 • Casework manager: Good. Can you confirm when a decision will be made, or is that also unknown?

07 • Service officer: I don't have a confirmed decision date, so I won't add one to make the correction seem reassuring.

08 • Casework manager: Please use the existing case reference and identify the appropriate status inquiry route.

09 • Service officer: I'll correct the original message in the same channel and keep the pending decision explicit.

10 • Casework manager: Thank you. An accurate correction is more helpful than preserving an ambiguous approval impression.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

The wrong office was named in a callback

Separate fictional case: a callback note named the licensing desk for a fee-query case; the service team has since confirmed the finance inquiry desk is the appropriate contact, but no outcome is known.

01 • Casework officer: We named the licensing desk in the callback, but the confirmed contact for this fee query is finance inquiries.

02 • Service supervisor: Please acknowledge the incorrect referral rather than simply send a new telephone number without explanation.

03 • Casework officer: I'll say our earlier direction was wrong and explain that finance inquiries handles the fee question.

04 • Service supervisor: Does that office have authority to grant the refund the constituent requested, or is that not established?

05 • Casework officer: We haven't established the outcome or refund authority. The confirmation concerns where the inquiry should go.

06 • Service supervisor: Keep those separate. A correct contact is not a promise that the requested remedy will be available.

07 • Casework officer: I'll ask the receiving desk how to provide a supported introduction using the existing case reference.

08 • Service supervisor: Good. Don't send additional personal material unless the relevant sharing process permits it.

09 • Casework officer: The corrected message will identify the appropriate inquiry desk and leave the substantive decision open.

10 • Service supervisor: That repairs the referral error while staying within our role in constituent casework.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Constituent Services and Escalation

A resident has been redirected between offices without an explanation of who can address the issue.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Second round: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Model for scenario 1: I'm sorry you have been redirected without a clear explanation. Let me identify the office with the relevant authority and confirm the next contact rather than send you on without that information.

Scenario 2 | A callback commitment was missed

A fictional casework office promised a callback on Tuesday but did not make it. It is now Wednesday, and the underlying case still has no decision. Discuss an apology and a realistic communication arrangement without inventing a case outcome.

Role A: You are the casework officer. Acknowledge the missed callback and distinguish it from the pending decision.

Role B: You are the service supervisor. Ask what contact you can genuinely arrange now.

Possible opening: We missed the callback we promised, and I need to acknowledge that separately from the pending case decision.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the missed communication clearly.
- Avoid claiming decision authority or a guaranteed outcome.
- Agree a feasible next contact and its limited purpose.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests promising approval to offset the service failure.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Transparency, Records, and Ethics

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

A records request involves material that may require review for an exemption. An initial note says all material will automatically be released.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

public records - Records held by public bodies and governed by applicable access and retention rules.

exemption - A defined exception to a rule or requirement under the applicable process.

conflict of interest - A situation where another interest may improperly influence a person's duties or judgment.

ethics - Principles and standards used to judge responsible conduct.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Compare this wording: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change definitely caused the delay.
 - B. The change may have contributed to the delay.
 - C. The change must have caused the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. In this pilot, the observed result was ...
 - B. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...
 - C. Across the service, the observed result was ...

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Located records are not cleared records

The lesson's public-records request may involve material requiring exemption review; an initial note incorrectly promises automatic release of everything.

01 • Records officer: The initial note promises automatic release of all material, but some records may require exemption review.

02 • Service communications lead: Can we say those records are exempt now, since a review has been identified?

03 • Records officer: No. A possible exemption is not a determination. We need the authorized review under the applicable process.

04 • Service communications lead: Then the correction should avoid both guaranteed release and a premature refusal.

05 • Records officer: Exactly. State that the request is being handled and distinguish located material from material cleared for release.

06 • Service communications lead: Should I add a standard deadline from another office's public-records webpage to reassure the requester?

07 • Records officer: Not without checking applicability. We must use the actual process and approved timing for this request.

08 • Service communications lead: I'll remove the automatic-release claim and obtain the responsible team's wording before responding.

09 • Records officer: Please preserve the uncertainty clearly rather than implying that review itself decides the outcome.

10 • Service communications lead: Understood. The response will describe the current status, not invent a release decision.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A declared connection is not a misconduct finding

Separate fictional case: a committee member discloses a prior professional connection with a bidder; the ethics review has not assessed it.

01 • Committee administrator: A member disclosed a prior professional connection with a bidder. Should the minutes call this a conflict of interest?

02 • Ethics coordinator: Record the disclosure accurately, but don't present a pending assessment as a concluded finding.

03 • Committee administrator: So the known fact is the disclosed connection, while its implications remain for authorized review?

04 • Ethics coordinator: Correct. Follow the applicable ethics process for participation questions rather than inventing a determination here.

05 • Committee administrator: Could we describe the member as having acted improperly because they raised the issue during the meeting?

06 • Ethics coordinator: No. The timing and disclosure do not establish misconduct. Keep allegations and verified facts distinct.

07 • Committee administrator: I'll use neutral wording and ask the responsible reviewer what next procedural action is required.

08 • Ethics coordinator: Good. Also avoid circulating unnecessary personal detail beyond the appropriate record and review channels.

09 • Committee administrator: The minutes will state that a connection was disclosed and that assessment remains pending.

10 • Ethics coordinator: That preserves transparency about the event without prejudging the ethics review.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A search result does not establish completeness

Separate fictional case: a records search returned files from the shared drive, but archived email has not yet been searched.

01 • Records search coordinator: The shared-drive search is complete, but archived email remains unchecked. We should not call the collection complete.

02 • Department liaison: The retrieved folder is large. Could we say all relevant records were found based on that volume?

03 • Records search coordinator: No. Volume doesn't establish completeness, especially while a known source has not been searched.

04 • Department liaison: I'll describe which source was searched and identify archived email as the outstanding part.

05 • Records search coordinator: Please also distinguish finding a file from assessing whether it belongs within the request's scope.

06 • Department liaison: And scope assessment is separate from any exemption or release review, correct?

07 • Records search coordinator: Correct. Those are distinct questions, and none should be treated as settled by a search result alone.

08 • Department liaison: I'll avoid promising a complete release package until the responsible team verifies those stages.

09 • Records search coordinator: Thank you. I'll coordinate the remaining search and report any access limitation rather than hide it.

10 • Department liaison: Then our status update can be specific about progress without claiming a finished public-records response.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Transparency, Records, and Ethics

A records request involves material that may require review for an exemption. An initial note says all material will automatically be released.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The request needs review under the applicable records process. I'll avoid promising a release decision before that review and explain how the office will communicate the outcome.

Scenario 2 | A missing attachment in a public record

A fictional records response identifies an email referring to an attachment, but the attachment has not been located. No exemption decision concerns that attachment yet. Discuss how to describe the gap and the next search step.

Role A: You are the records coordinator. State what has been found and what remains missing.

Role B: You are the department liaison. Challenge whether missing means deliberately withheld.

Possible opening: We located the email, but its referenced attachment has not yet been found.

Success checks

- Distinguish not located from withheld after review.
- Avoid claims about motive or exemption status.
- Agree the next authorized search or clarification step.

Add a complication: Someone wants to label the attachment exempt to explain its absence.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Performance Metrics and Budget Justification

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

A budget proposal lists activities delivered but does not show the intended public outcomes.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

appropriation - Funding authorized for specified public purposes through the relevant budget process.

outcome measure - An indicator used to assess whether an intended result occurred.

equity - Fairness in access or treatment; in finance, ownership interest or residual value.

public value - The benefit an activity creates for the community or people served.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Compare this wording: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
 - B. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
 - C. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?
 - B. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?
 - C. How would you describe the next step in your own words?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Activities delivered versus public outcomes

The lesson's budget proposal lists delivered activities but does not show the intended public outcomes.

01 • Budget analyst: The proposal lists activities delivered, but what public outcome is the requested appropriation intended to support?

02 • Program manager: We have described what staff did. We haven't yet connected those activities to a measured public result.

03 • Budget analyst: That is the distinction to explain: activity counts show work performed, while outcome measures show intended changes.

04 • Program manager: Could we call a higher activity count improved public value without collecting any other information?

05 • Budget analyst: Not automatically. More activity may matter, but it doesn't establish whether the intended benefit occurred.

06 • Program manager: I'll explain the intended result separately and identify the evidence we have not yet collected.

07 • Budget analyst: Please also consider equity: an overall total can hide differences in who can access the service.

08 • Program manager: I can raise that measurement question without claiming that the current program has solved access disparities.

09 • Budget analyst: Good. The justification should distinguish the purpose of funding from evidence of achieved outcomes.

10 • Program manager: I'll bring the activity information, intended outcomes, and open measurement questions to the budget discussion.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

More appointments, unchanged waiting time

Separate fictional case: a service office delivered 1,200 appointments this quarter, up from 1,000, while measured average waiting time remained ten days.

01 • Program director: We delivered twelve hundred appointments instead of one thousand. Can we describe that as faster access?

02 • Performance analyst: Not from these figures. Average waiting time remained ten days, so the access-speed measure did not improve.

03 • Program director: Then appointment volume is the output, while waiting time reflects a different aspect of service performance?

04 • Performance analyst: Yes. One counts activity, while the other measures how long people waited for it.

05 • Program director: The extra appointments still represent work, but they don't support the specific claim that access became faster.

06 • Performance analyst: Exactly. We can recognize higher volume without substituting it for the outcome measure.

07 • Program director: Should the appropriation discussion consider whether demand also increased during the same quarter?

08 • Performance analyst: Yes, as a relevant question. We haven't supplied demand figures, so don't invent an explanation yet.

09 • Program director: I'll present both measures and ask what else is needed to understand the public value of the increase.

10 • Performance analyst: That will give decision makers a clearer account than calling every higher count an improvement.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A citywide average hides access questions

Separate fictional case: a fictional digital-service pilot reports a citywide completion rate but has not examined outcomes for people using assisted access.

01 • Service transformation lead: The citywide completion rate is our main outcome measure. Does that fully describe whether the pilot improved access?

02 • Equity analyst: It describes the measured overall result, but we haven't examined people using assisted access separately.

03 • Service transformation lead: Could you explain why that matters without assuming the pilot disadvantaged that group?

04 • Equity analyst: An average combines experiences. Equity analysis asks whether access or outcomes differ across relevant groups.

05 • Service transformation lead: So it raises a question about distribution of benefit, not an automatic finding of unfairness.

06 • Equity analyst: Exactly. We need appropriate data and definitions before drawing a conclusion about any group.

07 • Service transformation lead: I'll avoid saying the overall rate proves equally successful access for everyone in the city.

08 • Equity analyst: Good. Explain what the measure covers and what remains unknown in the budget justification.

09 • Service transformation lead: Then we'll ask for an appropriate comparison of assisted and unassisted access within the pilot.

10 • Equity analyst: That can make the public-value discussion more informative while preserving the limits of the current evidence.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Performance Metrics and Budget Justification

A budget proposal lists activities delivered but does not show the intended public outcomes.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: The activity count tells us what was delivered. We also need to explain the intended outcome and how it will be assessed. I'll connect the spending request to that public-purpose question.

Scenario 2 | Training staff versus reducing errors

A fictional office trained forty staff to reduce application-processing errors. Training attendance is recorded, but before-and-after error rates are unavailable. Explain the distinction during a budget conversation and agree a suitable evidence question.

Role A: You are the program manager. State the training output and intended outcome separately.

Role B: You are the budget reviewer. Ask what would show whether processing improved.

Possible opening: Forty staff attended training, but we have not yet measured whether processing errors decreased.

Success checks

- Distinguish attendance from an achieved service outcome.
- Explain an outcome measure in everyday language.
- Agree what comparable evidence is needed without inventing results.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to label all forty attendees as forty demonstrated service improvements.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response to scenario 1, not a script to memorize. Assess your spoken version using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Policy Implementation and Program Rules

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: B - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

B: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

C: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

Check 2: A - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

B: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

C: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

Model response: The proposal is under review; the current published guidance remains the reference for today's process. Let me show you the distinction and where official updates will appear.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Public Meetings and Stakeholder Input

Editing example: Before I record agreement, does anyone have a concern or need more time?

The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Check 1: A - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view?

A: It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.

B: Silence does not establish agreement.

C: Recording agreement without checking may misrepresent the team's view.

Check 2: C - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options.

A: Discussion does not itself constitute approval.

B: Participation alone does not establish a decision.

C: This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

Model response: Let's return to the announced speaking process so more people can contribute. I'll summarize the points raised and invite the next speaker, while keeping the record clear about what remains unresolved.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Procurement and Vendor Selection

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: C - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

B: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

C: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

Check 2: B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

B: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

C: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

Model response: Which stated criteria support that assessment? Please connect the evidence to those criteria so the review explains the basis for the judgment rather than relying on a general label.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Grants, Compliance, and Reporting

Editing example: Could you send the missing document and confirm when it will be available?

The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Check 1: B - Send it no later than Thursday.

A: This interprets a deadline as a continuing activity, which would use "until".

B: 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.

C: "By Thursday" permits earlier delivery; it is not restricted to that day.

Check 2: A - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

A: The requested action and information are explicit.

B: This checks importance rather than identifying the needed document version.

C: This checks receipt, not which version is required for the review.

Model response: Could you provide the category breakdown and supporting references required for this report? If an item is unresolved, please identify it so the grants team can explain the next step.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Interagency Coordination

Editing example: Please confirm which team has accepted the follow-up task.

The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Check 1: A - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.

A: It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.

B: Mentioning a task does not show that anyone accepted it.

C: A written record alone does not identify who will act.

Check 2: C - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?

A: It changes pending information into a final result.

B: Receiving a message is not the same as confirming its meaning.

C: This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

Model response: Could we confirm which agency will make the next contact and by when? I'll record that responsibility and the permitted information-sharing route so the resident receives a coordinated response.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Constituent Services and Escalation

Editing example: I'm sorry my message did not explain the timing clearly.

The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Check 1: C - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear.

A: This acknowledges duration, but does not take responsibility for the unclear wording.

B: This acknowledges a missed date, not the communication problem in the question.

C: This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.

Check 2: B - The corrected date and the current confirmation status.

A: An unsupported new promise can create a second misunderstanding.

B: A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

C: The reader still lacks the information they need.

Model response: I'm sorry you have been redirected without a clear explanation. Let me identify the office with the relevant authority and confirm the next contact rather than send you on without that information.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Transparency, Records, and Ethics

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: B - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

B: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

C: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

Check 2: A - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

B: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

C: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

Model response: The request needs review under the applicable records process. I'll avoid promising a release decision before that review and explain how the office will communicate the outcome.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Performance Metrics and Budget Justification

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

B: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

C: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

Check 2: C - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

B: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

C: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

Model response: The activity count tells us what was delivered. We also need to explain the intended outcome and how it will be assessed. I'll connect the spending request to that public-purpose question.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Government and Public Administration English

Professional audience: public administrators, agency program managers, policy analysts, procurement staff, constituent-service teams, grants managers, and interagency coordinators

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Policy Implementation and Program Rules

Original fictional case: A resident mistakes draft eligibility guidance for a final rule. The office has published current guidance and a separate proposal.

Language workshop: Make a complex point clear

Communication goal: Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Language guidance: Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): In this context, ... means / The difference is that / How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Vocabulary: policy: Formal rule or standard that guides decisions and behavior. / eligibility: Rules that determine whether a person, account, provider, service, or request qualifies for a program, benefit, or action. / implementation: Putting an agreed plan, product, or process into operation. / public guidance: Official information explaining how a public program or process operates.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The proposal is under review; the current published guidance remains the reference for today's process. Let me show you the distinction and where official updates will appear.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level